

FIVE METAL MASONRY

Iconography Archive

Conceptual Content Architecture, Taxonomy & Search Framework

Platform-independent working specification. The framework defines what the archive must do; the technology and platform can be selected separately.

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1. Purpose and Platform Independence

The Iconography Archive is conceived as a structured, searchable home for Five Metal Masonry's existing and future iconography studies. Instagram can remain the public-facing publishing and discovery channel; the archive provides serious enthusiasts with systematic access to the accumulated corpus.

This document is intentionally platform-independent. The content model, taxonomy, metadata, ingestion workflow, search logic and user discovery experience described here are conceptual and functional requirements. They are not dependent on WordPress or any particular CMS, membership platform or technology stack.

A later platform evaluation should assess candidate technologies against this framework. Possible implementations could include a content management system, a purpose-built application, a suitable hosted platform or another architecture capable of meeting the requirements.

Core content principle: the existing visual study remains the content. Instagram carousel slides should be reusable substantially unchanged, without converting each study into a conventional article.

2. Content Corpus

The named study series are the primary editorial structure. No additional family-level classification is required.

Completed

Series	Scope
Panchaloha Primer	An introduction to the Panchaloha bronze art form.
Dictionary of Iconography	Glossary of terms related to iconography.
Tala	Series on iconometry and proportional systems.
BronzeCast	Studies and notes on bronze and the bronze tradition.
Mythics	Iconography of mythical characters.
108 Tandava	Iconography of the 108 dance poses of Siva.
Ayudha	Visual study of weapons and attributes held by divinities.

Ongoing

Series	Scope
Roopam	Iconography of minor and lesser-known divine forms.
God is in the Details	Detailed visual iconographic study of museum and temple bronzes.
5MM Iconography Quiz	Quiz-based engagement and learning around iconography.
Majors Iconography	Detailed thematic studies of major divinities; approximately 70 studies to date.
Mudra	Visual study of hand gestures, mudras and hastas.
108 Divya Desams	Iconography of Vishnu across the 108 Vaishnava shrines.
Abharana	Visual study of ornamentation and attire.
Temple Iconography	Visual study of temple architecture and sculptures.
Iconography Shelf	A guided view of books on iconography.

Upcoming

Series	Scope
Padimam	Visual study of stone sculptures in temples.
Vahana	Visual study of the mounts of divinities.
Asana	Study of postures.

3. Content Architecture

A **Study** is the fundamental unit of the archive. It is stored once and can be discovered through its Series and through multiple cross-series taxonomies. The taxonomy describes the study; it does not dictate how a study is created.

Majors Iconography may contain substantial thematic works. For example, *32 Forms of Ganesha* is one complete study. Individual forms discussed within such a study are indexed as metadata and point back to the complete authored study rather than being split into artificial sub-studies.

Recommended conceptual content types

Content type	Purpose
Study	Primary content type for visual carousel studies.
Dictionary Entry	Individual glossary/reference entry.
Quiz	Question, answer and explanatory content.
Book	Structured Iconography Shelf entry with bibliographic information and visual walkthrough.

Series remains flat. The archive exposes the named series directly. Rich cross-series organisation is handled by taxonomy and search, irrespective of the eventual platform.

4. Taxonomy

The visible architecture remains simple while the underlying taxonomy is rich. These classifications are conceptual data relationships and can be implemented in whichever platform is ultimately selected.

Divinity

Controlled terms such as Siva, Vishnu, Devi, Krishna, Ganesha, Skanda, Brahma, Surya, Hanuman, Ayyanar and others as required. A study may have more than one divinity.

Form

Identifiable iconographic forms such as Nataraja, Dakshinamurti, Kalyanasundara, Venugopala, Kaliya-mardana or Heramba Ganapati. In larger thematic studies these function as indexing terms.

Iconographic Elements

Parent	Examples
Ayudha & Attribute	Ankusa, Pasa, Trisula, Cakra, Sankha, Gada, Danta, Modaka, Aksamala, Kamandalu, Nilotpala...
Mudra & Hasta	Abhaya, Varada, Kataka and other gestures.
Asana & Sthana	Lalitasana, Sukhasana, Utkutikasana, Ardhaparyankasana, Svastikasana, Samapada, Abhanga, Tribhanga...
Abharana	Makara-kundala, Patra-kundala, Keyura, Kankana, Ekavali, Graiveyaka, Channa-vira, Mekhala, Nupura...
Headgear & Hair	Jata-makuta, Karanda-makuta, Kirita-makuta, Mauli, Dhammilla, Ekaveni...
Attire	Specifically identifiable garments and attire.
Vahana	Nandi, Garuda, Musika, Mayura, Simha, Hamsa and others.
Physical / Anatomical Feature	Ekadanta, multiple heads, multiple arms, third eye, human-headed Ganesha, three trunks and similar diagnostic features.
Other Elements	Accompanying figures, pedestal/support, sirascakra/aureole and architectural elements where materially relevant.

Place / Temple

Structured location metadata, particularly for Temple Iconography, Padimam, 108 Divya Desams and object-based studies.

Period / Dynasty

Optional terms such as Chola, Pallava, Pandya, Vijayanagara and Nayaka, used only where attribution is reasonably established.

Source / Reference

Optional structured references to texts, temple traditions, museum collections and scholarship; this can be enriched progressively.

Indexing rule

Index what is studied or materially discussed - not everything merely depicted. Automated suggestions should follow the same principle and remain reviewable.

Dictionary terms and taxonomy terms remain distinct but linked. A term such as Makara-kundala can index many studies and separately have a Dictionary of Iconography entry defining it.

5. Study Metadata & Automated Ingestion

Manual cataloguing of thousands of slides is not the intended workflow. Metadata should be created at **Study level**, assisted by OCR and AI across the complete carousel. The eventual platform should either support this workflow directly or allow it to be integrated.

Field	Use
Title	Required
Series	Required
Slides / visual carousel	Required
Divinity	Where applicable
Form(s) covered	Where materially discussed
Iconographic Elements	Where materially discussed
Place / Temple	Where applicable
Period / Dynasty	Optional
Source / Reference	Optional
Search aliases / keywords	Optional
Original publication date	Recommended
Access level	Public / Member
PDF / attachment	Optional

Three-layer indexing model

- 1. Extracted full text.** OCR/AI reads all slides in a carousel and stores the extracted text invisibly for deep search. This helps surface obscure terms even when they were not formally tagged.
- 2. AI-generated Study metadata.** AI analyses the complete carousel and proposes title, divinity, forms, iconographic elements, place, period and other relevant metadata.
- 3. Controlled taxonomy.** Proposed terms are mapped to the archive's preferred vocabulary so variants such as Jatamakuta, Jata Makuta and Jata-makuta do not become separate taxonomy entries.

Recommended ingestion / migration workflow

Import one complete carousel as one Study -> extract text from all slides -> generate suggested metadata -> compare suggestions against existing controlled terms -> flag genuinely new terms -> curator reviews/approves -> publish. The curator reviews the Study record, not every slide individually.

The archive can launch progressively. A migrated study may initially contain Series, title, carousel, primary divinity and extracted searchable text. Form, elements, place, period and references can be enriched later.

6. Archive Search & Discovery

Search is the principal value added by the archive. It should combine curated taxonomy with OCR/AI-derived full text rather than depend exclusively on either method. The exact search engine or software implementation is a later technology decision.

Archive landing page

A prominent search field followed by three primary discovery routes: **Browse by Series**, **Browse by Divinity** and **Browse by Iconographic Element**. Place and period can initially remain filters.

Ranked search behaviour

Search results should be ranked by strength of match. A formal taxonomy match such as *Divinity = Ganesha* ranks above a study in which Ganesha is only mentioned in extracted slide text. This combines scholarly precision with deep recall.

Search results should show why a study matched - for example its Series and selected controlled terms. These are reference cues, not social-media hashtags.

Browse by Series

Each named series has its own landing view. Larger series may include 'Search within this series' and relevant filters.

Browse by Divinity

Selecting a divinity produces a cross-series corpus without duplicating content.

Browse by Iconographic Element

Visitors can enter through controlled parent groups such as Ayudha & Attributes, Abharana, Mudra & Hasta, Asana & Sthana, Vahana and Headgear & Hair, then see materially relevant studies across the archive.

Filters

Filters appear after a search or within browse views. Initial filters: Series, Divinity, Iconographic Element, Place and Period/Dynasty. Mobile interfaces can use a single Filter control.

Autocomplete, aliases and spelling tolerance

Autocomplete should suggest controlled terms and study titles. Search should accept alternate spellings and common-language queries while displaying preferred terminology - for example Ganesa / Ganesha / Ganapati; siras chakra / sirascakra; mouse / musika.

Dictionary integration

Where a search term has a Dictionary of Iconography entry, the definition can be surfaced prominently, followed by related studies.

OCR/AI-assisted indexing

OCR and AI are core ingestion tools, but not the sole authority for indexing. Extracted slide text provides broad full-text search; AI proposes Study metadata; controlled taxonomy provides consistency and higher-quality ranking. This avoids manual tagging of thousands of slides while retaining scholarly control over terminology.

7. Version 1 User Experience

I know the series -> Browse by Series
I am studying a divinity -> Browse by Divinity
I am studying an iconographic feature -> Browse by Iconographic Element
I know exactly what I need -> Search

The visible experience remains deliberately simple. Rich taxonomy, AI-assisted metadata, extracted full text and cross-referencing operate underneath.

8. Platform Selection - Later Stage

The platform should be selected only after the conceptual and functional requirements are sufficiently defined. Candidate platforms should be evaluated against this framework rather than allowing the limitations of a particular platform to determine the archive's architecture.

Key platform capabilities to evaluate later include: preservation of carousel-based visual studies; structured metadata and controlled taxonomies; OCR/AI-assisted ingestion; strong full-text and faceted search; membership/access control; Indian and international payment support if paid access is introduced; mobile usability; performance with an image-heavy corpus; SEO; backup/export; and long-term data portability.

Principle: choose the technology to fit the archive - do not redesign the archive to fit a technology selected too early.

9. Architectural Principles to Carry Forward

1. Preserve established series identities.
2. Keep the Series structure flat.
3. Store each study once; use taxonomy for cross-series discovery.
4. Preserve each carousel as a complete authored study.
5. Do not split large thematic studies into artificial sub-studies.
6. Use OCR/AI to automate ingestion and first-pass metadata generation.
7. Maintain a controlled scholarly vocabulary for formal taxonomy.
8. Index what is materially discussed rather than everything merely visible.
9. Combine taxonomy matches with extracted full-text search and rank accordingly.
10. Allow progressive metadata enrichment rather than requiring perfect cataloguing before launch.
11. Keep the conceptual architecture independent of the eventual technology platform.
12. Evaluate platforms against the archive requirements only after the requirements are defined.